

Settled Before the System Switched On

Anticipatory Queue Reordering at a Primary School Gate, Before and After a Tap-On Dismissal Rollout

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Motivation

A school need not deploy a system to change what happens at its gate. Whether an announced-but-not-live tap-on dismissal rollout already reorders a pick-up queue's informal arrangements — and whether that reordering survives the system's actual arrival — remains untested.

Research questions

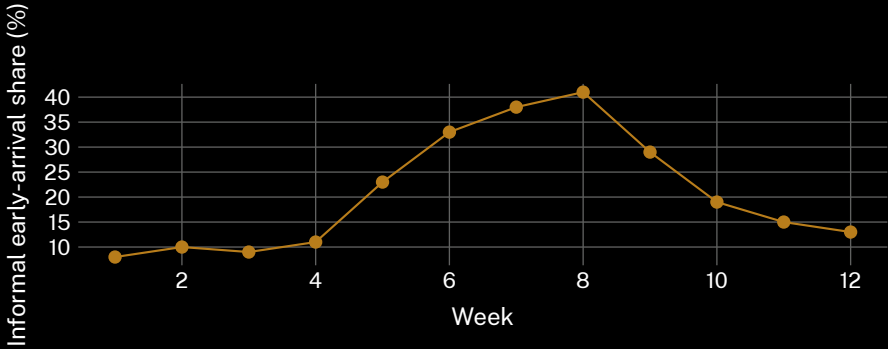
- Track the informal queue arrangement across the announcement-to-rollout window
- Test whether any pre-emptive reordering persists once the system is live
- Separate what the announcement changed from what the system itself changed

Study design

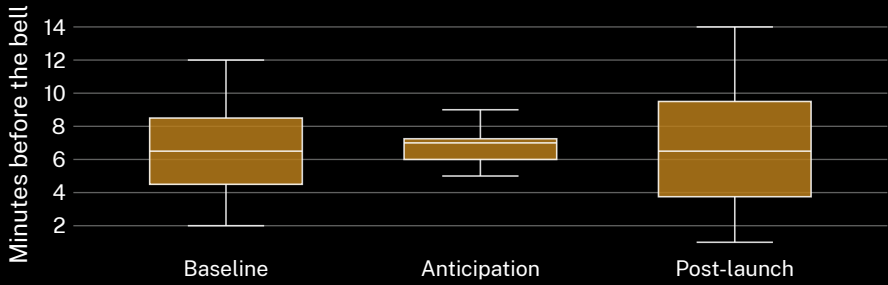
- 6 primary school gates, 2 feeder zones · discreet arrival-order observation, independent of the school's own dismissal-app data · 12 weeks
- fixed observation windows spanning baseline, announcement-to-live, and post-launch phases
- observers blind to each family's dismissal-app registration status; coding scheme cross-checked against a second rater

Findings

An informal early-arrival arrangement expanded sharply once the rollout was announced and contracted just as sharply once the system actually went live, settling near its pre-announcement level before the tap-on log had a full term of data behind it.



Share of families arriving via the informal early-arrival arrangement rose from a 9.5% baseline to 41% in the four weeks after the rollout's 3 March announcement, then fell to 13% within three weeks of the system's 14 April go-live.



Arrival-time spread compressed from a 2–12 minute range at baseline to 5–9 minutes during the anticipation window, then widened back out to 1–14 minutes after go-live — the same reversal, read off timing rather than headcount.

What it means

The announcement did the reordering; the system just watched it happen. Anticipation, not automation, moved the queue — and moved it back once there was nothing left to anticipate. Whatever the tap-on log eventually shows, it will be measuring a queue that had already re-settled itself.

Next: test whether a rollout announced with no fixed go-live date produces a reordering that never resolves.

Selected references

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We thank the staff and families of the observed pick-up zones. Arrival order logged only; no child identified, no numberplate retained; phase-window thresholds were pre-registered.